1. Introduction

Through this study, we hope to explore the relationship between fostered escapism and social media apps. Escapism was once considered to be the strongest predictor of online addiction (N. Yee, 2006). At the same time, it could be perceived as both "positive" and "negative" (Hagström D., Kaldo V, 2014) where it could even manifest as a form of self actualisation (A. Kardopoltseva, 2012). According to The American Psychology Association, escapism is the tendency to "escape from the real world to the safety and comfort of a fantasy world" when one feels stressful (Fort Behavioral Health, 2021). People use media to actively disengage themselves from troubling thoughts and unpleasant mood states caused by challenging life situations (Hastall, M.R., 2017). Mental escape has both negative and positive aspects. Apart from escaping from the cyber world "Avoiding the reality also refers to an immersion into psychotic illusions caused by altered states of consciousness, worlds created in one's imagination while reading fantasy books, listening to music, or watching pieces of art etc. Ultimately, the process of daydreaming and fantasizing can be considered as escaping from the real world as well." (Igorevna,2015). Mental escapism involves creating a mental or emotional distance from your current thoughts, feelings, or circumstances, often through imagination and entertainment. It's a way of seeking relief or distraction from stress, anxiety, boredom, or other uncomfortable emotions. Methodologies of the study includes interviews, focus group and experiments.

Scope of research
The purpose of the study is to understand the root cause, behavior and intentions for people to experience escapism, with the case study on Instagram. The duration of study will be 3 months, not limited to Hong Kong in the early stages.

Keywords
Escapism, Abuse, Addiction, Burnout, Experience, Mental wellbeing, Spirituality, Healing

2. Objectives of research

- Study the historical development of SMAs and escapism
- Research the factors that attract people to use Instagram
- Compare the functions and aesthetics between Instagram and other SMAs
- Investigate the behavior and causes behind
- Analyze the change of feeling during and after using Instagram

Historical development of the concept 'Escapism'

- How was the term 'escapism' born
- What did people think about it
- Any controversies over time

There are a number of aspects we would like to investigate. We prioritized them according to significance to our research. We put a heavier focus on (1) motivation and triggers, (2) How escapism was shaped by social and cultural context and their (3) effects on human.
Aspects with a higher importance were Indicated with a higher number of " * ".

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- **Definition and Conceptualization**: *
    - Begin by defining what mental escapism means and how it is conceptualized in the context of psychology, sociology, and related fields.
- **Motivations and Triggers**: ***
    - Explore the reasons why individuals engage in mental escapism. What triggers the desire to escape from reality? Is it primarily driven by stress, boredom, trauma, or other factors?
- **Types and Forms**: ***
    - Investigate the various forms of mental escapism, such as daydreaming, entertainment, hobbies, substance use, or social media. Understand how these different forms manifest and affect individuals.
- **Psychological and Emotional Impact**: ***
    - Analyze the psychological and emotional impact of mental escapism. How does it affect individuals' mental health and well-being? Does it provide relief or exacerbate underlying issues?
- **Positive and Negative Consequences**: ***
    - Examine both the positive and negative consequences of engaging in mental escapism. What benefits can it offer in terms of relaxation, creativity, and coping? What are the potential downsides, such as avoidance of problems and addiction?
- **Frequency and Patterns**: *
    - Study the frequency and patterns of mental escapism in different populations. Are there demographic or cultural factors that influence how often and in what ways people escape mentally?
- **Coping Mechanism vs. Avoidance**: *
    - Differentiate between healthy coping mechanisms that involve temporary mental escapism and unhealthy avoidance behaviors. Explore the line between seeking relief and avoiding necessary responsibilities or emotions.
- **Cultural and Societal Context**: ***
    - Consider how cultural and societal factors shape the practice of mental escapism. Are there cultural norms or expectations that influence how people cope with stress and discomfort?
- **Age and Developmental Stages**: *
    - Investigate whether the prevalence and nature of mental escapism vary across different age groups and developmental stages. Are there common patterns among children, adolescents, and adults?
- **Interventions and Support**: *
    - Explore interventions and support mechanisms for individuals who may rely excessively on mental escapism or for those who need healthier coping strategies. What therapeutic approaches or self-help techniques can be effective in managing escapism?
- **Long-term Outcomes**: ***
    - Research the long-term outcomes of relying on mental escapism as a coping mechanism. Does it lead to personal growth and resilience, or does it hinder emotional development and problem-solving skills?
- **Comparative Studies**: **
    - Conduct comparative studies to analyze how mental escapism compares to other coping mechanisms in terms of effectiveness and potential drawbacks.
- **Ethical Considerations**: **
    - Consider the ethical implications of mental escapism, especially in cases where it may involve harmful or addictive behaviors.
- **Cross-disciplinary Approaches**: **

- Collaborate with experts from psychology, sociology, neuroscience, and other relevant fields to gain a multidisciplinary perspective on mental escapism.

3. Methodology

- **Literature review**
  - Objective: Review existing bodies of research within the themes of escapism
  - Scope: in-app user behavior and effects of social media components such as Algorithms, Social Rewards, Feed UI/UX, and sensory stimulation.
- **Focus Group Interview & experiments**
  - Objective: understand how what users feel change before and after using social media apps
  - Number of participants: 4-5
  - Data gathered: Gather quantitative number on time (seconds) spent on social media apps and the percentage comparison between other apps

Set of sub-questions we would like to investigate:

Sub Questions	Type of data we want to collect	Rationale behind the type of data	Methods
Introduction What **attracts** people to use SMAs in terms of SMAs design	• What highlights of the design attracted the user • Color: Do differences in visual appeal e.g. BnW vs colored makes a difference? • Layout, icons, images, illustrations, and sounds (UX,UI,product,experience) • Algorithm	How do design elements of SMA (e.g. instagram affect Which design attribute of SMA attract users. Explore the relation between design elements of SMA and users' intention to use and experience when using them	Literature review
Sub Q1: BACKGROUND What were the intended, perceived and observable **functions** of SMAs overtime	• The development process of SMAs in history • How have the their target users and functions change • Display what content then and now	Understanding how SMAs has evolved over time from designers and users perspective (design research)	Literature review Fields of knowledge
Sub Q2: PROBLEM EXPLORATION How SMAs	• The groups / ages of people who use SMAs most • What is the average screen-time of SMAs (usage / level of addiction) • What are topics and specific things people use SMAs to search and	Understanding usage and the various pathways SMAs activates escapism and the usage and level of addiction, How the "doomscrolling" loop was	Case study Interview Talk to professionals Psychology books

activate escapism	why • What types of content do SMAs contain would make them more attractive? • Does the pace of content user perceive affect their attention level?	created	
Sub Q3: USER REFLECTIVE PRACTICE What do people feel and behave, before during and after using SMAs (wellbeing)	• Psychological changes before and after people use SMAs (level of happy, sad or no feeling) • Intended time of using vs in reality (subconscious drawn of attention into certain content and spent time) • Individuals amount of screentime used for SMAs each day and the percentage compared of the other apps • Unconsciously swiped topics while using the app SMAs	Measure whether SMA creates a positive or negative effect on mood; and the positive and negative impacts of using social media	Literature review - general impact Experiments Focus Group - feel and behave Framework analysis e.g. Pace of VDO like TikTok, immerse.

4. Timeline

Phase	Time	Activity
Research and Experiment/Interview Preparation	November Week 1	Finish literature review
	November Week 2	Finalize interview details and send out invitations
Conduct interview and experiments	November Week 3	Conduct 1st round of interviews
	November Week 4	Conduct experiments and analyze the data collected
Analysis of Information collected	December Week 1	Create final report draft
	December Week 2	Finish the final report for submission

5. Expected Outcome

Through our designed experiment, we hope to collect real-time insights on how perceived escapism affects how users interact and perceive with social media. By exploring the relationship between escapism and social media app usage, we hope to gain an understanding of how various user behaviors, such as ‘doom scrolling’ and long-term addiction to social media apps are formed. As a result, we aim to produce findings and discussions that are helpful to both social media app users and designers.

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